

Alex E. Combs

Assistant Professor

University of Georgia · Athens, GA 30602

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Academic Appointments

Assistant Professor of Public Administration and Policy Department of Public Administration and Policy, University of Georgia	2020-Present
Visiting Assistant Professor Department of Public Administration and Policy, University of Georgia	2019-2020
Post-Doctoral Researcher & Instructor Martin School of Public Policy and Administration, University of Kentucky	2018-2019

Education

Ph.D. University of Kentucky (Public Policy & Administration)	2018
M.A. University of Kentucky (Public Administration)	2014
B.A. Eastern Kentucky University (Political Science)	2009

Research

Peer Reviewed Publications

- [8] Combs, A., Foster, J.M., & Troland, E. (forthcoming). The Role of Property Assessment Oversight in School Finance Inequality. *National Tax Journal*.
- [7] Combs, A. (2026) Beyond Access and Enrollment: How Distance Relates to Persistence and Degree Completion Among Students Attending In-State Public Institutions. *Journal of Postsecondary Student Success*, 5(2), 6-29. https://doi.org/10.33009/fsop_jpss139199
- [6] Combs, A., & Kim, S. (2025). Constraints and Contributions: The Effects of Tax Limits on Education-Supporting Nonprofit Revenue. *Public Finance Review*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/10911421251385050>
- [5] Combs, A., & Afonso, W. (2025). Dollars, Desks, and Development: The Impact of Local Sales Tax Revenue Redistribution on Recipient Programs in North Carolina. *National Tax Journal*, 78(2), 295-326. <https://doi.org/10.1086/733594>
- [4] Afonso, W., Combs, A., & Buerger, C. (2024). Plugging the Tax Leak: An Analysis of North Carolina's Local Sales Tax Redistribution Policy. *State and Local Government Review*, 56(1), 76-90. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0160323X231215057>
- [3] Combs, A. (2023). High School Student Achievement and College Enrollment in the Absence of School Improvement Interventions: Evidence from Kentucky. *Public Finance and Management*, 22(1). <https://doi.org/37.808/pfm.22.1.4>
- [2] Combs, A., & Foster, J.M. (2021). The Effects of Homestead Exemptions for Seniors and Disabled People on School Districts. *American Education Research Association Open*, 7. <https://doi.org/10.1177%2F2332858420988712>

[1] Combs, A., Foster, J.M., & Toma E.F. (2018). Local Response to School Finance Equalization: Wealth or Place? *Public Finance and Management*, 18(3). <https://doi.org/10.1177/152397211801800301>

Works In Progress

[7] Combs, A. State Subsidy Mix and Postsecondary Institution Spending: Driving a Divergence in Education Quality and Amenities.

Revise & Resubmit, *Research in Higher Education*

[6] Afonso, W., & Combs, A. A Framework for Sales Tax Base Expansion: Food Taxation in North Carolina and Applications for Other States.

Revise & Resubmit, *Public Budgeting & Finance*

[5] Afonso, W., & Combs, A. Equity in Local Option Tax Policy: Rethinking What is Fair.

Under review, *American Review of Public Administration*

[4] Park, H., Combs, A., Kim, S., & Jung, J. The Influence of Special Districts on Local Nonprofit Markets: Evidence from County-Level Persistence and Relocation.

Under review, *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*

[3] Combs, A. Fiscal Illusion Under the Cover of Property Tax Limits: School District Revenue Responses to a Reordering of Tax Levy Options.

[2] Combs, A., & Afonso, W. Sharing the Burden: Did Sales Tax Redistribution Alleviate Excess Property Taxes in North Carolina Counties?

[1] Combs, A., & Kim, S. From Public Labels to Private Resources: The Nonprofit Revenue Response to School District Fiscal Distress Labels.

Conference Presentations

[22] Should We Put Food Back on the Table? An Examination of Food in the Sales Tax Base. 2025
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management

[21] Sharing the Burden: Did Sales Tax Redistribution Alleviate Excess Property Taxes in North Carolina Counties? 2025
Association for Budgeting and Financial Management

[20] Equity in Local Option Tax Policy: Rethinking What is Fair. 2024
Public Management Research Conference

[19] Equity in Local Option Tax Policy: Rethinking What is Fair. 2024
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management

[18] Dollars, Desks, and Development: The Impact of Local Sales Tax Revenue Redistribution on Recipient Programs in North Carolina. 2024
Association for Budgeting and Financial Management

[17] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. 2023
Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management

[16] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2023
[15] The impact of school district tax and expenditure limits on education-supporting nonprofit revenues. Southeastern Conference for Public Administration	2023
[14] School district TEL stringency and education-supporting nonprofit revenues: Crowding out community support to supplement school revenues. Korean Association of Public Administration	2023
[13] School district TEL stringency and the finances of education-supporting nonprofits: Crowding out community support to supplement school revenues. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2023
[12] Do nonprofits substitute educational resources in response to tax and expenditure limits on school districts? Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2022
[11] Property tax levies relative to predetermined options: Exploiting fiscal illusion? Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2022
[10] The effects of removing voter recall from school district property taxes. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2021
[9] The impact of state oversight on property assessments and school district revenues. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2019
[8] The effects of homestead exemptions for the disabled and the elderly on school districts. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2019
[7] High-tuition, high-aid policy and college expenditures. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2018
[6] Are state subsidies in higher education driving a divergence in institutional expenditures? Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2018
[5] The effect of NCLB waivers on college outcomes. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2017
[4] Local response to school finance equalization: The important of place. Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management	2017
[3] Local response to school finance equalization. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2017
[2] The effect of distance on degree completion. Association of Education Finance and Policy	2016
[1] Trends and determinants of state government privatization activity. Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2015

Research Assistance

Visiting Research Assistant, Kentucky Center for Statistics	2018-2019
Research Fellow, Council of State Governments	2013-2014

Teaching

University of Georgia

Data Applications in Public Administration	Fall 2019-Spring 2025; Spring 2026
Education Finance and Policy	Fall 2022
Introduction to the Nonprofit Sector	Fall 2020; Fall 2025; Spring 2026
Introduction to Public Policy Analysis	Spring of 2020, 2022, 2023, and 2024
Public Financial Management	Fall of 2019, 2021, 2023, and 2025
Faculty-Mentored Undergraduate Research I	Summer 2022

University of Kentucky

Public Program Evaluation	Spring 2019
Strategic Planning & Organizational Change	Fall 2018
Economic and Business Statistics	Spring 2017
Education: Economics and Policy (TA)	Fall 2015

Awards & Fellowships

[7] UGA Active Learning Summer Institute Fellow	2025
[6] Best Field Note of the Year in <i>State and Local Government Review</i>	2024
[5] UGA Student Career Success Influence Award	2024
[4] Busbee Endowment Seed Grant (\$13,200)	2021
[3] Graduate School Academic Year Fellowship, University of Kentucky	2016
[2] Graduate School Academic Year Fellowship, University of Kentucky	2015
[1] Daniel Reedy Award for Outstanding MPA Thesis, University of Kentucky	2014

Service

Students

Youkyoung Jeong, Public Administration (Ph.D.), University of Georgia, Dissertation Committee Member	2023
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Conferences

Panel Chair, Association for Budgeting and Financial Management	2025
Panel Chair, Southeastern Conference for Public Administration.	2023
Panel Discussant, Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management.	2022

Department, School, & University

Faculty Executive Committee, 2024
Department of Public Administration & Policy

College Curriculum Committee, 2020; 2023-Present
School of Public and International Affairs

Reviewer for Journals and Presses

AERA Open; Educational Researcher; Journal of Infrastructure, Policy and Development; Public Finance and Management; Routledge; State and Local Government Review

Media Commentary

Kiernan, J.S. (2023, Feb. 21) Property Taxes by State. *WalletHub*.

Kiernan, J.S. (2021, March 17) Most & Least Federally Dependent States. *WalletHub*.

Non-Academic Employment

Associate Director of Leadership Development, Sigma Nu Fraternity Inc. 2010-2013

Leadership Consultant, Sigma Nu Fraternity Inc. 2009-2010